

WHO GETS WHAT

Allocations were targeted to attract votes from across classes, castes, sectors and regions

FARMERS

DEBT WAIVER OF Rs 50,000 CRORE

ONE-TIME DEBT SETTLEMENT:

Rs 10,000 crore

TOTAL: Rs 60,000 crore

BENEFICIARIES: 200 million people, including 40 million farmers

IMPACT: 380 constituencies

REALITY CHECK: The V.P. Singh regime waived loans worth Rs 10,000 crore but still could not return to power.

GOVERNMENT EMPLOYEES

NOTHING IN THE BUDGET

But implicit guarantee in terms of acceptance of the Sixth Pay Commission

EXPECTED BILL: Over 1 per cent of GDP at Centre and states, **Rs 54,000 crore**

BENEFICIARIES: Over 12 million workers

IMPACT: Widespread

REALITY CHECK: It is not a guarantee. The acceptance of the Fifth Pay Commission didn't help the United Front government.

RURAL INDIA

BHARAT NIRMAN: Rs 31,280 crore

NREGA: Rs 16,000 crore

RAJIV GANDHI DRINKING WATER

MISSION: Rs 7,300 crore

TOTAL SANITATION: Rs 1,200 crore

BENEFICIARIES: 742 million populace

REALITY CHECK: There is a huge gap between promise and performance, outlays and outcomes, causing anti-incumbency.

SC & ST

SPREAD ACROSS 15 SCHEMES: Rs 3,966 crore

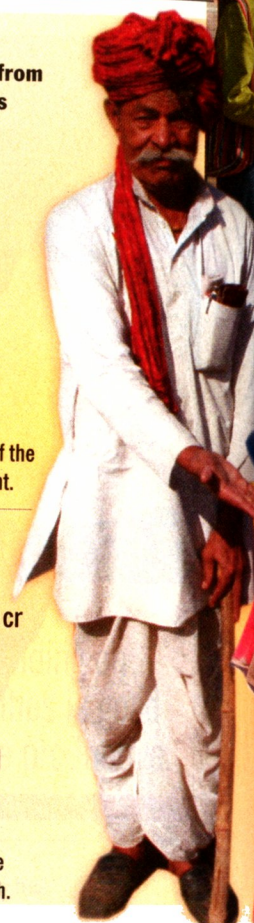
PLUS: 20 per cent share in major schemes, Rs 3,796 cr

BENEFICIARIES: A populace of 250 million, 150 million voters

IMPACT: For scs, 570 seats in Assemblies and 79 in Lok Sabha. For sts, 532 seats in Assemblies and 41 in Lok Sabha.

EXPECTED IMPACT: 120 constituencies

REALITY CHECK: It may help in other states but not where there is already a vote-catcher, like Mayawati in Uttar Pradesh.



little for farmers for four years, other than a badly-executed scheme in Vidarbha. Its criticism and questions on where the money came from were, however, lost in the hysteria that is the dialect of parties approaching polls. The Budget was tailored not just for farmers. Every allocation was targeted to attract votes from across classes, castes, sectors and regions (see box). The lynchpin, though, was the waiver,

signalling that UPA had put its money where its slogans were parked. It may not—and purists will vote on this—address the issues of inclusive growth, but it will appear to be addressing the issues of rising inequalities fuelled by high growth and the asymmetry between Bharat and India.

The timing couldn't have been better. Battered by the loss in Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh, the Congress

needed a shot of testosterone. For weeks, the allies had been campaigning with Sonia for an *aam aadmi* Budget. Hours before the Budget, Lalu beseeched UPA ombudsman and External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee to ensure a "pro-poor" slant. Outside, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi assured supporting groups that the Budget will be hailed "even in



ASSADUDDIN OWAIISI, LOK SABHA MP, ALL INDIA COUNCIL OF UNITED MUSLIMS'

“UPA has shown commitment in tackling minority issues. What is needed now is legislation to create equal opportunities.”

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